

Asop's Fable

With food in plenty, land ownership and fixed deposits, pigeons are on top of the heap in this Jodhpur village



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TRUSTEES SHOW FIXED DEPOSITS HELD BY THE 'KABUTARAN COMMITTEE'

By Rohit Parihar

Most people love to feed birds—either to earn brownie points with Mother Nature or out of concern for their well-being. But in Asop village, 100 km north of Jodhpur on the Nagaur Road, pigeons rule the roost with bank accounts and plots of land in their name. Not only that, villagers have gone a step further to create special feeding platforms for the birds. In a region known to love animals, Asop steals the limelight from its neighbours as it has set up a trust called the “Kabutaran Committee” (Committee for Pigeons) which handles land and fixed deposits for its feathered friends.

An ancient fort, still occupied by a Thakur family, is the core area for the pampered birds of this village. Pigeons from the fort have the first right to feed. Ordinary village pigeons aren't exactly neglected as Asop, with a population of 20,000, has 16 fenced platforms to feed them 32 quintals of different kinds of grain every month. “The custom has been on since the time of our ancestors,” says Shiv Karan Banta, vice-president of the trust. People donate land for the pigeons, which has added up to 225 acres. In a village where the average price of land is Rs 20,000 a bigha, many

people have willed a part of their holdings to the trust, which also has three shops. This land cannot be sold or transferred and nor can any kin of a donor reclaim it. The trust auctions the land for farming, parking and other purposes; the lakhs of rupees earned are used to buy grain. There are cash donations too which now make up a tidy fixed deposit of Rs 20 lakh. Bansi Lal Saboo, a chartered accountant who migrated to Mumbai and is a member of the trust, says: “Even the fines imposed on people for various wrongs are collected by the trust.” Their love for the pigeons knows no boundaries; the donations by Asop's residents are not confined to religious compartments.

With resources for the birds accumulating steadily, the trust has started paying attention to the plight of other animals. It recently donated Rs 10 lakh to shift a cow shelter from inside the village to its outskirts. Also, a plot of land for the pigeons has been occupied by cows. With eight ponds in the village, the trust intends to grow trees and develop a natural park around one of them to turn it into a bird habitat. For the villagers of Asop, their love for pigeons is not just a flight of fancy, it's a way of life. ■